

Searching With Google

Search, of course, is what Google is mostly about. Evolved out of their original research paper, *The Anatomy of a Large-Scale Hypertextual Web Search Engine* (<http://tinyurl.com/y98mbt>), the Google search engine is a distributed network of hundreds of thousands of computers that take about half a second to process a search query. Yes, one half of one second! For an overview of the technology, go to www.google.com/corporate/tech.html.

Building on this breakthrough approach to searching the Web, Google search has grown into a plethora of specialised services that enables people to search the Web in so many different useful ways. In this chapter we look at the various ways you can Google the Web for information.

7.1 Web Search

Web search is the most commonly used of Google's services. Fire up your Web browser, type in <http://www.google.com> to take you to Google's "classic" search page as shown here.



Google's classic search page

Note that if you are in India, typing in google.com will automatically redirect you to Google India's home page, www.google.co.in.

The first thing you notice is the minimalist look of the page.

This is a conscious design consideration intended to focus the user's attention on one and only one thing: searching for information. In the upper right corner you will notice two links: Personalized Home and Sign-in. The personalized home page takes you to a customisable home page which you can configure with your personal choices. See §7.3 to learn more on how to create a Google account and personalise Google with your preferences.

7.1.1 Search Overview

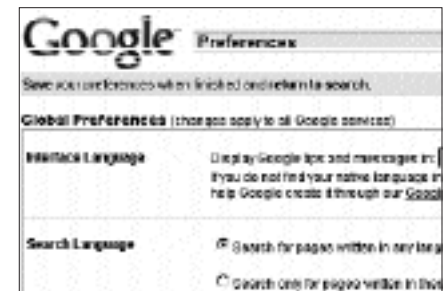
The most basic search involves entering a string of keywords in the search box and hitting the [Enter] key or clicking on the Google Search button. You can also click the "I'm Feeling Lucky" button; doing this will take you directly to the first Web site that Google thinks is the most relevant. Additionally, you have two other options before clicking either of these buttons: you can select whether Google should search the entire Web or just pages from India. Based on the options you select, the results of your search will differ. When you click on the Google Search button, the results displayed are ranked according to relevance and reliability using a complex formula that calculates the ranking (within half a second!) based on 500 million variables and 2 million search terms!

7.1.2. Search Preferences

You can specify how Google behaves on your computer by setting the Preferences accessible via the link next to the search box.

This will open a Web page where you can specify various settings on how Google should behave.

At this page you can specify the language in which the Google interface should be. On the



The Preferences page